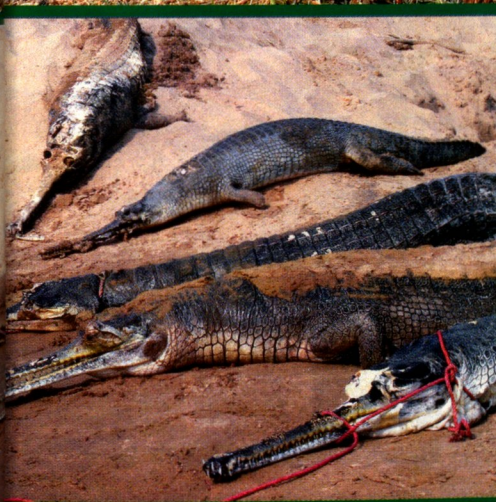


# ATTLE

Encroachers are running riot in the forests of Uttar Pradesh. The situation will only worsen if urgent steps are not taken.

Photograph by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



## HAPLESS, HELPLESS

- The state has forests over 21,883 sq km of area. Of these, 288 sq km are under the control of mafia.
- The land controlled by encroachers is worth almost Rs 2,663 crore.
- There are only 14,000 officials to look after the forests, with about half of them deployed in conservation work.
- Forest guards do not get any vehicles and have to patrol 10-12 sq km on foot.

killing or arresting notorious poachers?" he asks. "The police don't cooperate with us. At times, even criminal cases are registered against us because we expose the police-mafia nexus."

The case of divisional forest officer (DFO) Ramesh Pandey, who heads the Katarniaghat sanctuary, is a pointer to how forest officials are being targeted by organised criminals. The sanctuary was in a bad shape when Pandey took over three years back. Soon after, he launched a campaign against the forest mafia and poachers. In the last three years, Pandey has tackled poachers such as the Babaria gang, which has links to international smuggling

rackets, recovering tiger skin and bones, and Rs 4 lakh in cash from them. He has also booked powerful criminals like Ashok Gaur and Jung Hindustani—a self-proclaimed activist who has several cases registered against him under the Forest and Wildlife Act—recovering forest timber worth Rs 32 lakh from them. The Wildlife Protection Society of India recognised Pandey's efforts and rewarded him for his campaign against the poachers. But some of his seniors and a section of politicians belonging to the Samajwadi Party and BJP were not so happy. Now criminal cases have been slapped against Pandey, a complaint under the SC/ST Act

## DAMAGED: Illegal tree-felling (top); gharials dead near Chambal shore

lodged and an aggressive campaign launched against him through locals led by Hindustani, with malicious slogans painted on walls around the sanctuary. When he had exposed a timber-smuggling racket which led to the suspension of an additional superintendent of police, the police had launched a non-cooperation movement against forest officials. "We are basically compelled to either surrender before the mafia who are gobbling up the forests or made to run from pillar to post," rues a forest officer.

The list of land-grabbers includes Billy Arjan Singh, who was awarded the Padma Shri and Padma Bhushan for forest and wildlife conservation, and lives on the periphery of Dudhwa park in Tiger Haven, a private farm spread over 250 acres. According to K.K. Singh, DFO of North Kheri, Arjan Singh has grabbed nearly 40 acres of the reserve. Rahul Shukla, an author of wildlife books, has filed a PIL along with social activist Rajesh Bharti in the high court for eviction of the mafia, including Arjan Singh, from the land. 90-year-old Singh, however, rebuts all charges. "The officials and so-called conservationists are telling lies. Why would I grab land at this age?"

The PIL also draws the attention of the government and courts to other handicaps faced by conservationists. Shukla and Bharti have sought construction of overbridges for vehicular traffic inside sanctuaries to allow free movement for wildlife in the forest. The traffic and movement of trains—30 trains pass through Dudhwa park everyday—is taking a heavy toll on the animals. On December 5, a full-grown tiger died after being hit by a speeding truck. "A number of wild animals, including elephants and tigers, are being run over by trains in and around Dudhwa. So, the state government should either divert the trains and traffic through some other route or develop overbridges," stated Shukla and Bharti in their petition. They have gone to the courts after they felt frustrated by the attitude of the state authorities towards forest conservation. By the time the courts finally wake the government up from its slumber, it could well be too late. ■